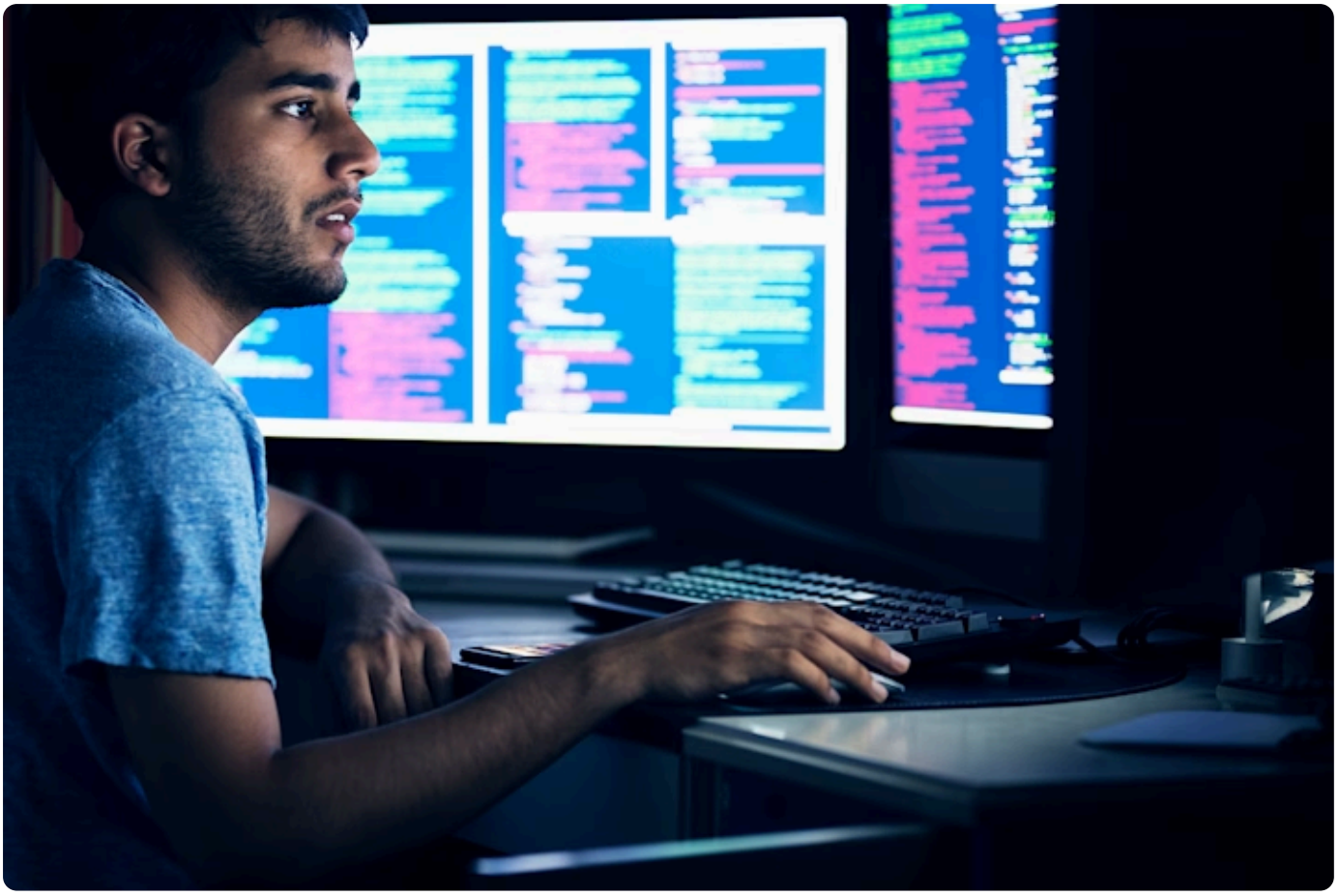
What Does a Database Administrator Do? (Plus Requirements and Salary)

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KEY TAKEAWAYS:

- A database administrator (DBA) manages and maintains software databases, such as client records, statistical surveys, census information, user accounts and library catalogs.
- If you're interested in information technology and database management, a career as a database administrator (DBA) may be right for you.
- To determine whether this role aligns with your career goals, it's important to learn what exactly it entails and what qualifications would improve your candidacy.

If you're interested in information technology and database management, a career as a database administrator (DBA) may be right for you. DBAs maintain and secure databases to protect sensitive information. To determine whether this role aligns with your career goals, it's important to learn what exactly it entails and what qualifications would improve your candidacy.

In this article, we explain what a database administrator does and discuss the job's expectations, including the average salary and typical work environment.

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What does a database administrator do?

A database administrator (DBA) manages and maintains software databases, such as client records, statistical surveys, census information, user accounts and library catalogs. They provide secure access to databases and manage backup solutions to prevent data loss in the event of a system failure. They may also help develop the stages of a database system.

Additional responsibilities may include:

- Creating new user accounts and permissions
- Testing modifications to database structures
- Monitoring database systems for slow responses or bottlenecks
- Optimizing database systems with regular updates and patches
- Regularly updating anti-virus programs on database servers
- Troubleshooting and diagnosing problems and implementing solutions
- Merging old databases
- Performing capacity planning
- Monitoring the hardware and operating systems of database servers

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Database administrator requirements

The following are the typical requirements for starting a career as a database administrator:

Education

Some database administrators enter the profession with a high school diploma and after earning relevant experience in the information technology industry. Many employers prefer DBAs with a bachelor's degree in disciplines such as information systems, computer engineering or computer science. DBAs can increase their earning potential by pursuing a master's degree in computer science, data science or business administration.

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Training

Most DBA training takes place on the job. Upon their hiring, DBAs typically learn specifically about the databases and procedures particular to their employer. A variety of continuing education opportunities are available as well, including conferences and seminars.

Skills

DBAs can use a variety of hard skills, including:

- **Database languages and management systems:** Effective database administration requires an in-depth knowledge of relevant database languages and applications, such as SQL, MySQL, SAP and Oracle.
- **Server operating systems:** Because databases exist alongside server operating systems, DBAs may benefit from knowing about systems like Windows Server, Linux and Unix.
- **Desktop operating systems:** Desktop administrators may sometimes install the client end of database applications or assist users with database-related issues. Effective administrators know about common operating systems such as Windows, MacOS and Linux.
- **Hardware component installation:** DBAs have a basic understanding of the parts included in a server in case it's necessary to replace any malfunctioning components. Hardware includes the motherboard, central processing unit, random access memory and hard drive.
- **Backup solutions and data restore:** The backup and restoration of database servers are important responsibilities of database administrators. They decide on the most effective backup solutions and are able to restore databases when required.
- **Capacity planning and database design:** Database administrators also perform capacity planning to develop processes for situations like extended storage space and more user licenses.
- **Cloud-based databases:** As many organizations are shifting from on-premises to cloud-based storage, familiarity with cloud architecture can greatly improve your candidacy for DBA roles.
- **Big data technologies:** An increasing number of organizations now expect DBAs to perform activities related to data science, namely identifying and surfacing business-relevant data from very large data sets. DBAs would benefit from learning about NoSQL DBMS technologies to understand how big data can be used.
- **Artificial intelligence (AI) and machine learning:** Having AI and machine learning skills can help DBAs to automate routine tasks, predict and prevent potential issues, strengthen security protocols, optimize database performance and improve their career prospects.
- **Containerization:** This refers to a software deployment process that bundles software code with the operating system and files necessary to run the code. As a skill, it allows DBAs to manage databases more efficiently.

DBAs can also develop soft skills, such as:

- **Communication:** The DBA role requires frequent communication with managers, information technology support members, database users, developers and other organizational members. The ability to communicate effectively with many different people helps DBAs to complete tasks quickly and efficiently.
- **Problem-solving:** DBAs monitor and evaluate a range of IT-related aspects when managing database systems. This requires the assimilation of complex information to devise creative solutions and implement them quickly and decisively.
- **Critical thinking:** DBAs evaluate situations and implement solutions in fast-paced environments. Excellent critical-thinking skills allow them to make effective data-based decisions.

Read more: Database Administrator Skills for Job Seekers

Certifications

Though not a strict requirement, DBA-related certification can maximize your chances of landing a DBA position by validating your expertise with a specific database. High-value certification options include:

Microsoft SQL Server Database certification

The Microsoft SQL Server Database certification is an entry-level credential that validates basic DBA skills. After earning this certification, you can pursue a variety of Associate-Level Microsoft Solutions certifications. You may benefit from learning basic SQL server skills before starting the three-exam requirement.

Related: **Guide to 14 Unique Database Administrator Certifications**

IBM Certified Database Administrator certification

The IBM Certified Database Administrator certification verifies your ability to navigate an IBM database server. Earning this credential requires passing two knowledge and skills exams. The first exam tests you on fundamental knowledge of daily administration tasks, Structured Query Language (SQL), IBM database security and creating database objects. The second exam evaluates your ability to perform advanced database tasks in security and migration.

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Average database administrator salary

The national average salary for a DBA is $90,037 per year. Annual salaries may range from around $60,000 to more than $133,000. A variety of factors may influence specific earning potential, including experience and location. For example, DBAs who work in Washington, D.C., report salaries that are 17% higher than the national average, at $105,093 per year.

For the most up-to-date salary information from Indeed, click on the link provided.

Database administrator work environment

Computer-system design companies employ the most DBAs, followed by other businesses and institutions that have large databases, such as universities and government departments. DBAs may also often work in telecommunications, banks or the healthcare sector. They typically work in offices or server rooms. The job involves long periods of sitting and working on computers.

DBAs usually work full-time salaried positions. Many employers employ contract DBAs to assist with special database projects, like upgrades and migrations. Most DBAs can expect to work overtime or on call, meaning there may be additional pay opportunities available.

How to become a database administrator

Though there are multiple paths to becoming a DBA, the following steps can provide you with the greatest chance of entering the profession:

1. Earn your bachelor's degree

Most DBAs opt for a bachelor's degree in either information systems or computer science. A typical bachelor's degree can take anywhere from three to five years to complete. If possible, try to complete an internship during your studies, as practical experience can benefit you when looking for employment.

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2. Gain knowledge of database languages and management systems

In addition to your education, specialized knowledge in your field can greatly improve your candidacy for a DBA position. Database languages and database management systems are two valuable skills for success in this profession. SQL and MySQL are two subjects you may want to learn. Including these on your resume serves as evidence of commitment to your field.

3. Obtain a certification

When you have familiarized yourself with database languages and management systems, you can obtain a specialized certification. Certifications show employers that you have a thorough understanding of specific topics. They also allow you to expand your knowledge in the database field.

Related: How To Become a Database Administrator

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Database Administrator Hiring Insights

Average pay

$110,770 / year

Low $36,000 **High** $226,000

Job seekers

31,842

+8 since August 2026

Employers hiring

610

+610 with open roles this month

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Sample database administrator job description

Here's a sample job description that can help you better understand what might be expected of you in a database administrator role:

We're looking for a junior database administrator to assist our database management team. Duties include installing and configuring new database servers, monitoring system health and security, managing user accounts and monitoring and troubleshooting database performance. Successful candidates receive on-the-job training and may take on additional responsibilities over time, including tasks like database design and implementation.

Our ideal candidate has a bachelor's degree in either computer science or information systems. We prefer candidates with an IBM Certified Database Administrator certification, but we're happy to consider those with other types of industry-standard credentials.

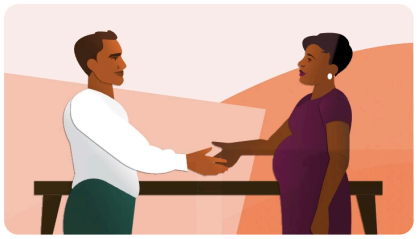
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